

HowardAI

Interface Design Language

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O. Introduction

HowardAI's Interface Design Language, or IDL, is a comprehensive design language that can be applied universally throughout any HowardAI interface. It clearly sets the guidelines and standards for UI/UX to ensure consistency, accessibility, and cohesiveness across all HowardAI interfaces.

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If you believe there is something incorrect, missing, or misplaced in this document, please notify the contact below:

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1. Color System

This section includes all colors, both brand and interface, that will be present in HowardAI applications and interfaces.

a. HowardAI Brand Colors

Brand Accent



HEX – #EBC736

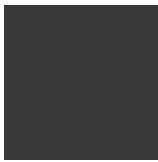
RGB – 235, 199, 54

CMYK – 0%, 15%, 77%, 8%

DO: Logo, progress bars, checked checkboxes, selected radio buttons, decorative highlights, borders, focus rings.

DON'T: Background of any kind, text color of any kind.

Primary Dark Background



HEX – #3A3A3B

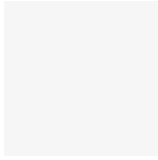
RGB – 58, 58, 59

CMYK – 2%, 2%, 0%, 77%

DO: Dark section backgrounds, footer backgrounds, dark surface layers.

DON'T: Body text color on light backgrounds, instead use #000000.

Primary Light Background



HEX – #F6F6F6

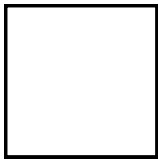
RGB – 246, 246, 246

CMYK – 0%, 0%, 0%, 4%

DO: Alternating table rows, subtle section differentiation, secondary card fills when slight elevation above the page canvas is needed.

DON'T: Use as the base page canvas, instead #FFFFFF.

Secondary Light Background



HEX – #FFFFFF

RGB – 255, 255, 255

CMYK – 0%, 0%, 0%, 0%

DO: The background of everything. Every page, every section by default, every modal, every input field, every card surface.

DON'T: Confuse with the secondary surface. This is the base, not an elevated layer.

b. Semantic Colors

Primary Action (Default)



HEX – #0EA5E9
RGB – 14, 165, 233
CMYK – 94%, 29%, 0%, 9%

DO: Buttons, links, active controls, interactive elements, info state indicators.

DON'T: Use for decorative or non-interactive elements. Never compete with #EBC736 in the same component.

Primary Action (Hover)



HEX – #38BDF8
RGB – 56, 189, 248
CMYK – 77%, 24%, 0%, 3%

DO: Hover state for any element using the Primary Action Default color.

DON'T: Use as a default or resting state color.

Primary Action (Active)



HEX – #0284C7
RGB – 2, 132, 199
CMYK – 99%, 34%, 0%, 22%

DO: Pressed or active state for any element using the Primary Action Default color.

DON'T: Use as a default or hover state color.

Success (Default)



HEX – #34C759

RGB – 52, 199, 89

CMYK – 74%, 0%, 55%, 22%

DO: Completed actions, healthy system indicators, online status, positive confirmations.

DON'T: Use for interactive elements – success is a status color, not an action color.

Success (Hover)



HEX – #30D158

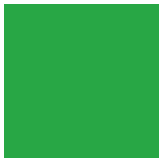
RGB – 48, 209, 88

CMYK – 77%, 0%, 58%, 18%

DO: Hover state for interactive elements carrying a success state.

DON'T: Use as a default resting color.

Success (Active)



HEX – #28A745

RGB – 40, 167, 69

CMYK – 76%, 0%, 59%, 35%

DO: Pressed state for interactive elements carrying a success state.

DON'T: Use as a default or hover state color. Never use as a background.

Error/Destructive (Default)



HEX – #FF3B30

RGB – 255, 59, 48

CMYK – 0%, 77%, 81%, 0%

DO: Failures, delete actions, validation errors, destructive confirmations.

DON'T: Use for warnings or cautionary states – that role belongs to #FF9F0A.

Error/Destructive (Hover)



HEX – #FF453A

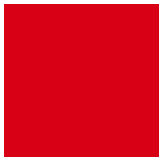
RGB – 255, 69, 58

CMYK – 0%, 73%, 77%, 0%

DO: Hover state for any destructive or error interactive element.

DON'T: Use as a default resting color.

Error/Destructive (Active)



HEX – #D70015

RGB – 215, 0, 21

CMYK – 0%, 100%, 90%, 16%

DO: Pressed state for any destructive or error interactive element.

DON'T: Use as a default or hover state color.

Warning (Default)



HEX – #FF9F0A

RGB – 255, 159, 10

CMYK – 0%, 38%, 96%, 0%

DO: Attention required, caution states, non-critical system alerts.

DON'T: Use for errors or failures – that role belongs to #FF3B30. Never use as a background.

Warning (Hover)



HEX – #FFB340

RGB – 255, 179, 64

CMYK – 0%, 30%, 75%, 0%

DO: Hover state for any interactive element carrying a warning state.

DON'T: Use as a default resting color.

Warning (Active)



HEX – #CC7A00

RGB – 204, 122, 0

CMYK – 0%, 40%, 100%, 20%

DO: Pressed state for any interactive element carrying a warning state.

DON'T: Use as a default or hover state color.

c. Text Colors

Primary Text (Light Backgrounds)

Aa HEX – #000000
 RGB – 0, 0, 0
 CMYK – 0%, 0%, 0%, 100%

DO: All headlines, body copy, and labels on light backgrounds (#F6F6F6 or #FFFFFF).

DON'T: Use on dark backgrounds, instead #FFFFFF.

Primary Text (Dark Backgrounds)

Aa HEX – #FFFFFF
 RGB – 255, 255, 255
 CMYK – 0%, 0%, 0%, 0%

DO: All text on dark backgrounds (#3A3A3B or similarly dark surfaces).

DON'T: Use on light backgrounds, instead #000000.

Secondary Text (Light Backgrounds)

Aa HEX – #6B6B6B
 RGB – 107, 107, 107
 CMYK – 0%, 0%, 0%, 58%

DO: Supporting copy, captions, metadata, and any text requiring softer contrast than #000000 on light backgrounds.

DON'T: Use on dark backgrounds, instead #FFFFFF

d. Disabled State

No dedicated color assigned.

All disabled components use their normal color at 45% opacity.

DO: Apply 45% opacity to the entire disabled component uniformly.

DON'T: Allow opacity reduction to bring text contrast below a readable threshold against its background. If it does, set the text specifically to #3A3A3B at 45% opacity rather than the component's native color.

e. Usage Philosophy

Yellow – "This is our company."

Blue – "You can interact with this."

Green – "This succeeded."

Red – "This failed."

Orange – "Pay attention."

Grays – "Structure, layout, and hierarchy."

f. Color Violations

Example 1 – Using #EBC736 as a button fill.

DON'T:

Submit

DO:

Submit

Example 2 – Putting any text directly on #EBC736.

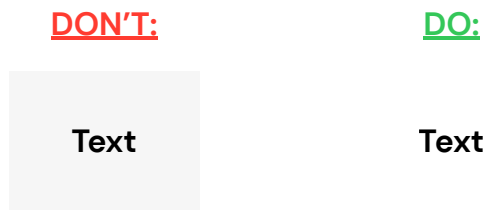
DON'T:

Text

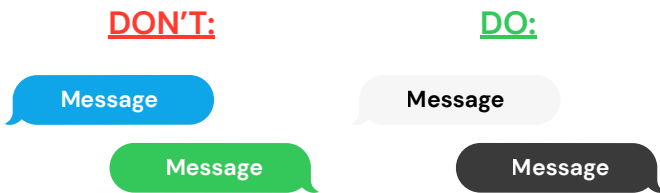
DO:

Text

Example 3 – Using #F6F6F6 as the page background instead of #FFFFFF.



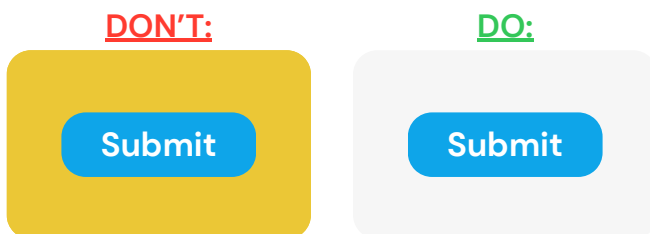
Example 4 – Using semantic colors for decoration.



Example 5 – Applying the disabled opacity rule to text without checking contrast.



Example 6 – Competing yellow and blue on the same component.



2. Typography

This section includes all typography standards for HowardAI interfaces, including type scale, text style, spacing, and weight.

a. Type Scale

HowardAI uses DM Sans for our primary typeface. Below is the type scale for each text style present in a HowardAI interface.

Display – 56px, Bold

H1 – 40px, Bold

H2 – 32px, Bold

H3 – 24px, Bold

H4 – 18px, Bold

Body Large – 18px, Regular

Body – 16px, Regular

Caption – 13px, Regular

LABEL – 11px, BOLD, UPPERCASE

a. Line and Letter Spacing

Display	Line Height: 1.05 Letter Spacing: -0.03em
H1	Line Height: 1.1 Letter Spacing: -0.02em
H2	Line Height: 1.15 Letter Spacing: -0.01em
H3	Line Height: 1.25 Letter Spacing: -0.01em
H4	Line Height: 1.3 Letter Spacing: 0em
Body Large	Line Height: 1.4 Letter Spacing: 0em
Body	Line Height: 1.4 Letter Spacing: 0em
Caption	Line Height: 1.5 Letter Spacing: -0.01em
Label	Line Height: 1 Letter Spacing: -0.08em

3. Spacing and Layout

All spacing in Howard interfaces derives from a single base unit of 4px. Every margin, padding, and gap value used across any Howard surface.

This system exists to create visual rhythm and structural consistency across all surfaces.

a. Spacing Scale

space-1	4px	Tightest internal gap. Icon-to-label spacing, inline element separation.
space-2	8px	Internal padding for small components. Badges, tags, chips.
space-3	12px	Button padding. Gap between label and input field.
space-4	16px	Standard component padding. The default internal spacing for most components.
space-6	24px	Gap between separate components within the same content group.

space-8	32px	Gap between distinct content groups within a section.
space-12	48px	Gap between major sections on a page.
space-16	64px	Hero and large section internal padding.
space-24	96px	Page-level vertical padding for full-width sections on desktop.

b. Padding vs. Margin

Padding is the space between a component's border and its internal content.

Margin is the space between a component and adjacent elements outside it.

These serve different structural purposes and must not be used interchangeably. A card's internal breathing room is padding. The gap between two cards is margin. Both values must come from the spacing scale.

c. Grid System

All content on all surfaces aligns to a defined column grid. Nothing floats outside the grid.

Desktop

Columns: 12

Max content width: 1200px

Gutter: 24px

Outer margin: 80px

Tablet

Columns: 8

Max content width: 768px

Gutter: 20px

Outer margin: 40px

Mobile

Columns: 4

Max content width: 390px

Gutter: 16px

Outer margin: 20px

The outer margin on mobile is the minimum safe distance from the screen edge. No interactive or readable content may sit closer than 20px to the edge of the screen on any mobile surface.

d. Content Width

Body content on desktop must never exceed 1200px. On wide viewports the outer margins expand — the content width stays fixed. Text-heavy content blocks such as paragraphs and captions should be additionally constrained to a maximum of 680px line length for readability. Lines longer than this become difficult to read across.

e. Vertical Rhythm

Sections on the website and Arken interface use consistent vertical padding to create page rhythm. The standard section padding is 96px top and bottom on desktop, 64px on tablet, and 48px on mobile. Deviation from these values requires explicit justification.

f. Do's and Don'ts

DO always select a value from the spacing scale. If a space feels too tight or too loose, move one step up or down the scale.

DON'T use arbitrary values such as 13px, 22px, or 35px. These break visual rhythm and create misalignment that compounds across surfaces.

DO give content room to breathe. When uncertain between two spacing values, choose the larger one.

DON'T apply identical spacing values to both padding and margin on the same component without deliberate reason. They serve different structural roles.

DO increase outer margins as viewport width increases. Content should never stretch edge to edge on wide desktop viewports.

DON'T allow any content or interactive element to sit closer than 20px from the screen edge on mobile.

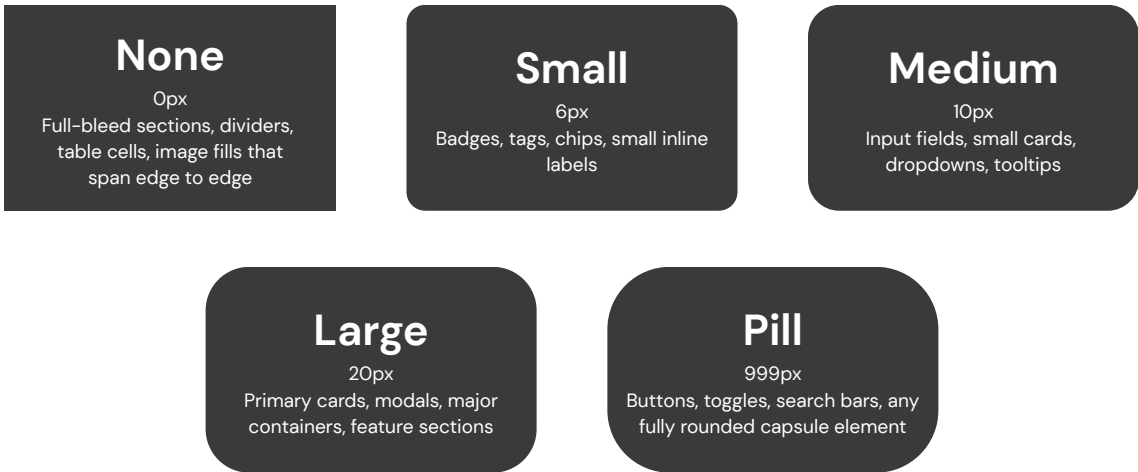
DO maintain consistent vertical section padding across equivalent sections. Inconsistent section heights create an unfinished appearance.

DON'T use spacing to compensate for missing content. Empty space should be intentional, not a placeholder.

4. Shape and Elevation

This section defines all corner radius and elevation values used across HowardAI applications and interfaces, establishing the visual depth and shape language of every component and surface.

a. Corner Radius



b. Elevation Guide

Level 0	No shadow	Used for inline elements
Level 1	Very subtle shadow	Used for cards at rest
Level 2	Medium shadow	Used for cards on hover or dropdowns
Level 3	Strong shadow	Used for modals and floating panels.

5. Motion and Animation

This section defines how content moves in HowardAI interfaces. Movement communicates meaning to users, and is very important in adding depth to interfaces. However, movement used excessively or spontaneously confuses and frustrates users.

Motion in Howard interfaces serves one purpose, which is to communicate state. Something entering the screen, responding to interaction, completing a process, or leaving the screen. Every animation must justify its existence by answering the question: what does this movement tell the user?

Motion that exists purely for aesthetic reasons is a violation of this system.

Easing defines the acceleration profile of a movement — how it starts and how it ends.

a. Easing

Never use spring or bounce easing. Howard interfaces are calm and deliberate. Bouncing elements undermine the brand's quiet confidence.

ease-out	Starts fast, decelerates to rest	Elements entering the screen. Feels natural, mimics physical objects coming to a stop.
ease-in	Starts slow, accelerates to exit	Elements leaving the screen. Feels intentional, content moves away with purpose.
ease-in-out	Slow start, fast middle, slow end	Elements moving from one position to another on screen.
linear	Constant speed throughout	Progress bars and loading indicators only.

b. Duration Scale

Nothing in a Howard interface animates for longer than 500ms. Animations exceeding this duration feel sluggish and test user patience.

duration-instant	100ms	Immediate feedback. Checkbox state change, radio button selection, toggle flip.
duration-micro	150ms	Hover state color transitions. Button press feedback. Focus ring appearance.
duration-short	250ms	Dropdown open and close. Tooltip appearance. Small component transitions.
duration-medium	350ms	Modal entrance and exit. Page-level component transitions. Card hover elevation.
duration-long	500ms	Full page transitions. Onboarding step reveals. Section fade-ins on scroll.

c. Animations

DO animate the following elements in HowardAI interfaces:

- Button and interactive element hover and press states
- Dropdown and modal entrance and exit
- Toast and alert appearance and dismissal
- Page and section scroll reveals
- Progress indicator advancement
- Focus ring appearance on keyboard navigation
- Toggle and checkbox state transitions

DON'T animate the following elements in HowardAI interfaces under any circumstances:

- Static text and body copy
- Page backgrounds and surface colors
- Logo and brand marks
- Table rows and data content
- Error and validation messages — these must appear immediately without delay
- Any element inside a disabled state

d. Reduced Motion

All animations must respect the user's system-level reduced motion preference. When a user has enabled reduced motion on their device, all transitions default to instant opacity changes with zero movement. No exceptions. This is both an accessibility requirement and a user trust signal.

e. Do's and Don'ts

DO use ease-out for all entrances. It is the most natural feeling easing curve for appearing elements.

DON'T animate more than three elements simultaneously on the same screen. Simultaneous motion across multiple elements creates visual noise and loses meaning.

DO keep all animations under 500ms. When in doubt, use a shorter duration. Interfaces that feel fast feel trustworthy.

DON'T loop animations. Nothing in a Howard interface moves continuously except progress indicators actively communicating an ongoing process.

DO use linear easing exclusively for progress bars. Any other easing on a progress indicator creates a false impression of speed or slowness.

DON'T add motion to error messages or validation feedback. These must appear instantly, because delay creates user anxiety.

DO respect reduced motion preferences at the system level. This is non-negotiable.

DON'T use animation to mask slow performance. If a screen takes too long to load, the solution is performance optimization, not a longer animation to fill the gap.

6. Iconography

HowardAI utilizes Tabler icons, which is a free, open-source library of free, SVG icons. The link to access Tabler's icon library is tabler.io/icons.

a. Stroke Weight

Stroke weight will always be 2px. Stroke weight for icons should never be 1px. as this makes icons seem too thin and may cause them disappear at small sizes. Stroke weight should never be 3px either, as this is too heavy and appears chunky.

b. Size Scale

There are four size scales for icons:

16px – Inline text icons

20px – Navigation and buttons

24px – Cards and feature callouts

32px – Hero feature icons

c. Style

HowardAI uses Tabler outline icons exclusively. Filled icon variants are never used under any circumstance. Mixing outline and filled icons within the same interface breaks visual consistency and is a violation of this system.

d. Coloring

Icons always inherit the color of their surrounding context. The context determines the icon color — the icon never introduces its own independent color.

On light backgrounds (such as #FFFFFF or #F6F6F6), icons are #000000.

On dark backgrounds (like #3A3A3B), icons are #FFFFFF.

On colored semantic backgrounds, icons match the semantic color. A success state icon is #34C759. An error state icon is #FF3B30.

#EBC736 is never used as an icon color. Yellow is a brand accent applied to structural elements — borders, focus rings, progress bars, checkboxes, and decorative highlights. It is not a color that icons inherit from context.

e. Icon Use Violations

DON'T use an icon without a functional or communicative purpose. If removing the icon doesn't change the user's understanding of the interface, it shouldn't be there.

DON'T use icons as substitutes for clear labels in unfamiliar contexts. Icons alone without text labels are only acceptable for universally understood symbols, such as home, search, close, and settings. Everything else requires a text label.

DON'T place two icons directly adjacent to each other without text separation. Back-to-back icons without labels create visual confusion about which icon belongs to which function.

DON'T use decorative icon clusters or grids of icons as a design pattern to fill space. This is a common violation, such as when rows of icons with captions are used as a section filler. If the content doesn't warrant icons contextually, use typography instead.

7. Components

This section defines every reusable interface component used across HowardAI applications and interfaces. Each component is specified with its variants, states, and usage rules. These definitions are the single source of truth for how every building block of Howard's interfaces looks and behaves. No component should deviate from what is defined here. This is to ensure a maximum level of consistency across our interfaces.

a. Buttons

Buttons are the primary interactive elements used to trigger actions across all Howard interfaces. Every button must be able to clearly communicate what will happen when pressed, who can press it, and whether it is currently available for interaction. Howard uses four button variants, each with a defined purpose that must not be substituted.

i. Primary Button

The main action on any screen. There should never be more than one primary button visible at a time. Used for the single most important action available to the user at that moment.



Background: #0EA5E9

Text: #FFFFFF

Border: none

Border Radius: pill

Text size: 16px Body, Bold

States:

Default: #0EA5E9 background

Hover: #38BDF8 background

Active: #0284C7 background

Disabled: #0EA5E9 background with 45% opacity. Check for text readability.

ii. Secondary Button

A supporting action that exists alongside a primary button. Used when the user has two meaningful options: one primary, one secondary. Never used alone without a primary button present in the same context.



Button

Background: #FFFFFF

Text: #000000

Border: 1px solid, #C4C4C4

Border Radius: pill

Text size: 16px Body, Bold

States:

Default: #FFFFFF background, #C4C4C4 border

Hover: #F6F6F6 background, #A3A3A3 border

Active: #EEEEEE background, #A3A3A3 border

Disabled: full component at 45% opacity. Check for text readability.

iii. Outlined Yellow Button

This is the only permitted use of #EBC736 on a button, and is used exclusively when a brand accent CTA is needed and the surrounding context makes a yellow accent appropriate. This is not a general-purpose button, rather a deliberate brand moment used sparingly.



Button

Background: transparent

Text: #000000

Border: 1.5px solid, #EBC736

Border Radius: pill

Text size: 16px Body, Bold

States:

Default: transparent background, #EBC736 border

Hover: transparent background, #D9B528 border

Active: transparent background, #C5A11A border

Disabled: full component at 45% opacity. Check for text readability.

iv. Destructive Button

Used exclusively for irreversible actions, including deleting data, removing a user, or resetting a configuration. Never used for general actions. This must always be accompanied by a confirmation step before execution.



Button

Background: #FF3B30

Text: #FFFFFF

Border: none

Border Radius: pill

Text size: 16px Body, Bold

States:

Default: #FF3B30 background

Hover: #FF453A background

Active: #D70015 background

Disabled: #FF3B30 background with 45% opacity. Check for text readability.

v. Key Notes

- All buttons use pill border radius without exception.
- Button labels are always verbs. "Save Changes" not "Changes." "Delete Account" not "Account Deletion." "Get Started" not "Start."
- Never place two primary buttons in the same view. If two actions feel equally important, one of them is secondary.
- Never use yellow as a button fill. The outlined yellow variant exists for specific brand accent moments only. It is not a substitute for the primary button.
- Minimum button touch target on mobile is 44px height regardless of visual size.
- Icon-only buttons must always include an accessible label for screen readers even if no visible text is present.

vi. Do's and Don'ts

DO use one primary button per view to anchor the main action clearly.

DON'T use the destructive button for anything reversible. If the action can be undone, it is not destructive.

DO always include a confirmation step before a destructive button executes its action.

DON'T use the outlined yellow button as a default CTA. It is a brand accent moment, not a standard interactive pattern.

DO ensure disabled buttons communicate unavailability clearly. A tooltip explaining why the button is disabled improves the experience significantly.

DON'T change the border radius of any button. All buttons are pill shaped. No exceptions.

b. Input Fields

Input fields are the components through which users enter any information into Howard interfaces. They appear in forms, search bars, settings panels, and Arken's setup flow. Every input field must clearly communicate its current state, such as what it expects, whether it is active, whether its content is valid, and whether it is available for interaction.

i. Text Input (Single Line)

The standard input field. Used for short-form text entry, such as names, email addresses, search queries, and configuration values.



Background: #FFFFFF

Text: #000000

Placeholder text: #A3A3A3

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-medium

Text size: 16px Body, Regular

Height: 44px minimum

States:

Default: #FFFFFF background, #C4C4C4 border

Focused: #FFFFFF background, 2px solid #EBC736 border, #EBC736 focus ring 2px offset

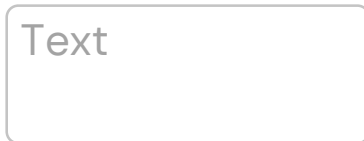
Filled: #FFFFFF background, #C4C4C4 border, #000000 text

Error: #FFFFFF background, 2px solid #FF3B30 border

Disabled: full component at 45% opacity. Confirm text remains Check for text readability.

ii. Text Input (Multi Line)

Used for long-form text entry, including messages, descriptions, notes, and task instructions. Functionally identical to the single line input with one addition: the field expands vertically as content grows. It never scrolls internally. Minimum height is 120px.



Background: #FFFFFF

Text: #000000

Placeholder text: #A3A3A3

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-medium

Text size: 16px Body, Regular

Minimum height: 120px

States: identical to single line input.

iii. Search Input



Used exclusively for search functionality. Visually identical to the single line text input with one addition being a search icon (“ti-search”, 20px, inherits context color) anchored to the left interior of the field.

The search icon is decorative and non-interactive. It never functions as a submit button. Search executes on keystroke or on return key press.

iv. Select Input

Used when the user must choose one option from a predefined list. Appears as a single line input with a chevron-down icon (ti-chevron-down, 20px) anchored to the right interior. On interaction it opens a dropdown panel displaying all available options.

A rectangular input field with rounded corners, a light gray border, and a white background. The word "Select" is displayed in a dark gray font on the left side. On the right side, there is a small, dark gray chevron-down icon.

Background: #FFFFFFF

Text: #000000

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-medium

Height: 44px minimum

States: identical to single line input. The dropdown panel that appears on interaction follows the dropdown component specifications defined in 7e.

v. Input Labels

Every input field must have a visible label positioned above the field. Labels are never placeholder text alone. Placeholder text disappears when the user begins typing. A label that only exists as placeholder text leaves the user without context once they start entering information.

Email Address

A rectangular input field with rounded corners, a light gray border, and a white background. The placeholder text "name@email.com" is displayed in a light gray font. Above the field, the label "Email Address" is positioned in a dark gray font.

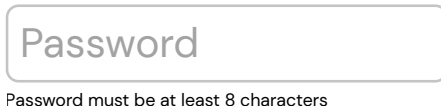
Label text size: 13px Caption, Regular

Label color: #000000

Label position: directly above the input field, 8px gap between label and field top edge.

vi. Helper Text

Optional supporting text positioned directly below an input field. Used to provide formatting guidance or context before the user interacts.



A rectangular input field with rounded corners and a light gray border. Inside the field, the word "Password" is written in a light gray font. Below the field, the text "Password must be at least 8 characters" is displayed in a smaller, light gray font.

Text size: 13px Caption, Regular

Color: #A3A3A3

Position: 4px below the input field bottom edge.

vii. Error Text

Required when an input field enters an error state. Replaces or follows helper text directly below the field. Communicates specifically what is wrong and how to fix it. Must never be generic or vague, for instance, "Invalid input" is not acceptable. "Enter a valid email address" is correct.



A rectangular input field with rounded corners and a light gray border. Inside the field, the text "name@email" is written in a light gray font. Below the field, the text "ⓘ Please enter a valid email address" is displayed in a red font, with a small red icon to the left of the text.

Text size: 13px Caption, Regular

Color: #FF3B30

Icon: ti-alert-circle 16px, #FF3B30, inline left of error text

Position: 4px below the input field bottom edge.

viii. Key Notes

The minimum height of 44px for all input fields is a mobile touch target requirement. This applies on all surfaces, not mobile only.

Never use placeholder text as a substitute for a visible label. Placeholder text is formatting guidance only, for instance, "name@email.com", not "Enter your email address."

The focused state always uses the #EBC736 focus ring. This is the only place yellow appears on an input field. It never appears as a background or text color within the field.

Error messages appear immediately on the relevant field. They never appear as a toast or modal. The error must be co-located with the field that caused it.

viii. Do's and Don'ts

DO always pair every input field with a visible label above it.

DON'T use placeholder text as the sole label. It disappears on interaction and leaves the user without context.

DO display error text immediately and specifically on the field that failed. Never delay error feedback.

DON'T use a generic error message. Every error message must tell the user exactly what is wrong and how to correct it.

DO maintain the 44px minimum height on all surfaces including desktop. This is not a mobile-only rule.

DON'T apply a yellow background to any input field state. Yellow on an input field is limited to the focused border and focus ring exclusively.

DO allow multi-line inputs to expand vertically with content. Never force internal scrolling on a text area.

DON'T remove the visible label on mobile to save space.

c. Cards

Cards are contained surface elements that group related information or actions into a single bounded unit. They appear across all Howard interfaces, such as in product tier cards on the website, feature cards, capability tiles, settings panels, and content containers. A card is never decorative. Every card contains meaningful, actionable, or informational content.

i. Standard Card

The default card used across all surfaces for general content grouping.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 24px

Shadow: none at rest

Hover state:

Border: 1px solid #A3A3A3

Transition: duration-micro (150ms), ease-out

ii. Elevated Card

Used when a card needs to appear visually above the surface it sits on. Modals, floating panels, and priority content containers.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 24px

Shadow: 0px 4px 24px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.08)

Hover state: shadow deepens to 0px 8px 32px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.12)

Transition: duration-micro (150ms), ease-out

iii. Featured Card

Used when one card in a group needs to be visually distinguished as the recommended or primary option. Used on the product tier section of the website.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 24px

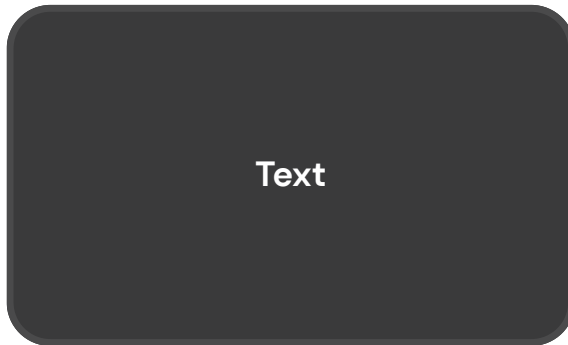
Shadow: 0px 4px 24px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.08)

Hover state: shadow deepens to 0px 8px 32px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.12)

Transition: duration-micro (150ms), ease-out

iv. Dark Card

Used within dark background sections, such as footers, privacy sections, or pages where dark surfaces are contextually appropriate.



Background: #3A3A3B

Border: 1px solid #4A4A4B

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 24px

Text: #FFFFFF

Shadow: none

Hover state: border color lightens to #6B6B6B

Transition: duration-micro (150ms), ease-out

v. Card Anatomy

Every card follows a consistent internal structure top to bottom:

1. Icon or image is optional. If present, sits at the top of the card above all text. Icons use 24px size, inherit context color.
2. Headline: H3, 24px Bold. The primary label of the card's content.
3. Body: Body, 16px Regular, #525252. Supporting description or content.
4. Action is optional. A button or text link anchored to the bottom of the card. If present, always separated from body content by a minimum of 24px.

No card contains more than one primary action. If multiple actions are needed, reconsider whether the content belongs in a card at all.

vi. Key Notes

Cards never use #F6F6F6 as a background when sitting on a #FFFFFF page background. The contrast difference is too subtle and creates an unintentional muddiness. Cards on white backgrounds are always white with a visible border.

Cards on #F6F6F6 secondary surface backgrounds may use #FFFFFF to create elevation contrast. Use of a white card on light grey surface reads as elevated without a shadow.

Never nest a card inside another card. If content complexity requires nesting, the component needs to be redesigned.

Card padding is always 24px on all four sides. Never reduce card padding below 16px regardless of card size.

Cards in a grid always share the same height within the same row. Content inside shorter cards aligns to the top. It never vertically centers to fill the card height.

vii. Do's and Don'ts

DO use a visible border on all standard cards on white backgrounds. A card without a border on a white background is invisible.

DON'T nest cards inside cards. Restructure the content instead.

DO align all cards in a grid to the same height per row. Inconsistent card heights in a grid create visual instability.

DON'T reduce padding below 16px inside any card. Content that feels cramped inside a card undermines the entire component.

DO use the featured card variant to distinguish one recommended option in a group. Never feature more than one card in the same group.

DON'T add multiple primary actions to a single card. One card, one primary action.

DO maintain radius-large on all card variants without exception. Never use radius-small or radius-medium on a card.

d. Navigation

Navigation is the persistent way-finding system that orients users across all Howard interfaces. It tells the user where they are, where they can go, and how to get back. Navigation must always be visible, always be consistent, and never require the user to think about how to use it.

Howard uses three distinct navigation patterns, one per surface. They share the same design language but are structurally adapted to their context.

i. Website Navigation (Top Bar)

The primary navigation for the Howard AI website. Sticky, it remains fixed at the top of the viewport as the user scrolls. Never disappears, never collapses on desktop.

Height: 72px

Background: #FFFFFF at 82% opacity with backdrop blur 18px

Border bottom: 1px solid #C4C4C4 at 4% opacity

Max content width: 1200px, centered

Logo is anchored left. Always the full HowardAI wordmark. Never the secondary icon-only logo in the navigation bar unless screen width forces it below 375px.

Navigation links are anchored right. Regular, 16px Body, #000000 at 82% opacity. On hover: #000000 at 100% opacity. Active page link: #000000 at 100% opacity, no underline, no additional treatment.

Navigation items with subpages use a dropdown on hover. Dropdown behavior defined in 7e.

Primary CTA button is optional. Anchored far right of navigation links. Uses primary button spec from 7a. Used only when a single high-priority action warrants persistent visibility, such as a pre-order or waitlist CTA.

Mobile breakpoint: 900px. Below this width the desktop navigation links are hidden and replaced by a hamburger menu button (ti-menu-2, 24px, #000000) anchored right. Tapping opens the mobile menu panel.

ii. Mobile Menu Panel

Appears when the hamburger button is tapped on mobile. Slides down from the navigation bar.

Background: #ODODOD at 98% opacity, backdrop blur 24px

Top position: 72px (directly below the navigation bar)

Width: 100% of viewport

Padding: 30px

Transition: duration-short (250ms), ease-out

Navigation links inside the panel: Bold, 18px H4, #FFFFFF. Each parent item with subpages uses a native HTML details/summary element tapping expands sublinks beneath it. Sublinks: Regular, 16px Body, #B7B7B7.

The panel closes when the user taps the hamburger button again, taps any navigation link, or taps outside the panel area.

iii. Mobile App Navigation (Bottom Tab Bar)

The primary navigation for the Howard mobile app. Fixed to the bottom of the screen, always visible, and never hidden behind content.

Height: 64px plus device safe area inset

Background: #FFFFFF

Border top: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Tab count: 4 maximum. 5 tabs is the absolute limit and only permitted when all five destinations are equally critical.

Each tab contains:

Icon – Tabler outline, 24px, centered above label

Label – 11px Label Bold, centered below icon

Gap between icon and label: 4px

Tab states:

Default – icon and label #A3A3A3

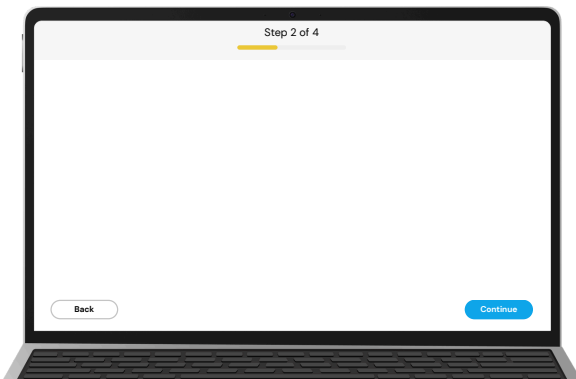
Active – icon and label #0EA5E9

Pressed – icon and label #0284C7, scale 0.95, transition duration-instant (100ms)

The active tab indicator is color only with no underline, no background pill, and no badge unless communicating an unread count. Unread count badges use #FF3B30 background, #FFFFFF text, 11px Label Bold, pill shape, positioned top right of the icon.

iv. Arken Interface Navigation (Setup Flow)

Arken's primary interface during Feature 1 setup is a full-screen step-by-step flow. This is not a persistent navigation bar, it is a progress-driven interface where the user moves linearly through configuration steps.



Navigation within the setup flow consists of two elements only:

Step indicator – top center of screen. Shows current step and total steps. Format: "Step 2 of 4". Regular, 13px Caption, #A3A3A3.

Progress bar – directly below the step indicator. Full width of content area. Height 4px. Background #EEEEEE. Fill #EBC736. Border radius radius-pill. Advances proportionally with each completed step. Transition duration-medium (350ms), linear easing.

Back and Continue buttons – bottom of screen. Continue uses primary button spec. Back uses secondary button spec. Continue is disabled until all required inputs on the current step are completed. Never show a back button on the first step.

Once setup is complete, Arken transitions to its operational interface. The operational interface navigation pattern is defined separately as it is a post-launch Feature 5 deliverable and outside current scope.

v. Key Notes

The website navigation background uses opacity rather than a solid fill to allow page content to show subtly beneath it while scrolling. This requires backdrop blur to remain readable. Never remove the backdrop blur without also making the background fully opaque.

The mobile app bottom tab bar never uses more than four tabs at launch. Feature 5 defines the full mobile interface, so tab structure will be specified at that time.

The Arken setup flow never uses a persistent navigation bar. The step indicator and progress bar are the only wayfinding elements during setup. Adding a full navigation bar to a linear setup flow creates confusion about whether the user can navigate away.

Never hide the navigation bar on scroll on any surface. Disappearing navigation forces users to scroll back to the top to navigate. This is a friction point that undermines the experience.

vi. Do's and Don'ts

DO keep the website navigation sticky at all times on desktop. It never scrolls away.

DON'T hide navigation items behind a hamburger menu on desktop. The hamburger is a mobile-only pattern.

DO use color alone to indicate the active tab in the mobile bottom bar. No additional visual treatment is needed.

DON'T exceed four tabs in the mobile bottom bar at launch. Every destination added to the tab bar reduces the clarity of every other destination.

DO disable the Continue button in the Arken setup flow until all required fields on the current step are complete. Never allow the user to advance on an incomplete step.

DON'T show a back button on the first step of the Arken setup flow. There is nowhere to go back to.

DO always show the full HowardAI wordmark logo in the website navigation bar. The secondary icon-only logo is a last resort for extreme width constraints only.

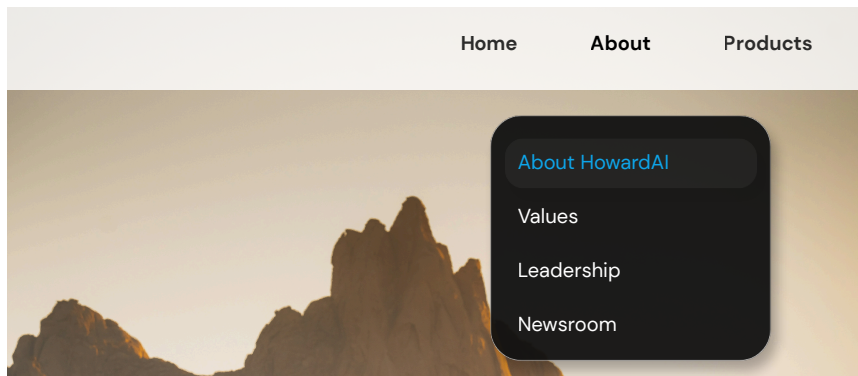
DON'T add decorative elements or additional colors to the navigation bar. It is a way-finding tool, not a branding surface.

e. Dropdowns

Dropdowns are layered panels that appear above the current interface surface to present a set of options or navigation links. They are triggered by user interaction, such as hovering on desktop navigation, tapping on select inputs, and clicking on action menus. Dropdowns are temporary surfaces. They appear with purpose and dismiss immediately when their purpose is fulfilled.

i. Navigation Dropdown

Appears on hover over a parent navigation item in the website top bar. Contains grouped links to subsections of the parent destination.



Background: #111111 at 96% opacity, backdrop blur 20px

Border: 1px solid #FFFFFF at 5% opacity

Border radius: radius-medium

Padding: 18px 14px

Min width: 200px

Shadow: 0px 20px 50px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.45)

Position: centered below the parent navigation item, 8px gap between nav bar bottom and dropdown top edge

Entrance: opacity 0 → 1, translateY 8px → 0px, duration-short (250ms), ease-out

Exit: opacity 1 → 0, translateY 0px → 8px, duration-short (250ms), ease-in

Individual link items inside:

Padding: 10px 12px

Border radius: radius-medium

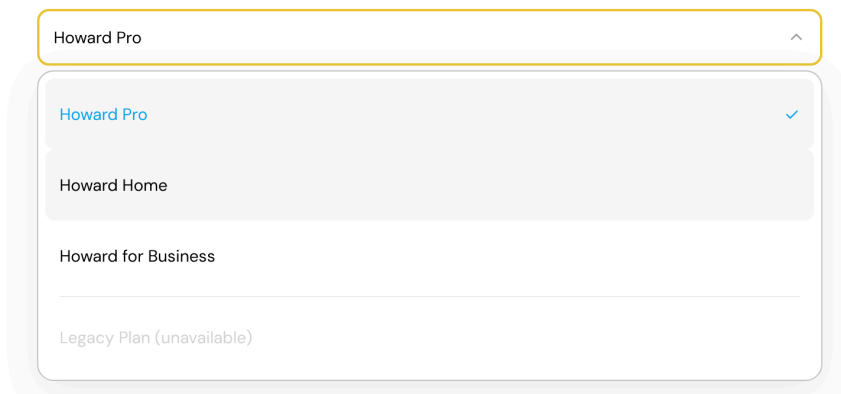
Text: 16px Body, Regular, #FFFFFF at 85% opacity

Hover: background #FFFFFF at 5% opacity, text #0EA5E9

Transition: duration-instant (100ms), ease-out

ii. Select Dropdown

Appears below a select input field when the user taps or clicks it. Presents a list of options the user can choose from. Replaces native browser select behavior with a consistent Howard-styled panel.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-medium

Padding: 8px

Min width: matches the width of the select input it originates from

Max height: 240px. If options exceed this height the panel scrolls internally.

Shadow: 0px 8px 32px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.08)

Position: directly below the select input field, 4px gap

Entrance: opacity 0 → 1, translateY 4px → 0px, duration-short (250ms), ease-out

Exit: opacity 1 → 0, duration-micro (150ms), ease-in

Individual option items inside:

Height: 44px minimum

Padding: 10px 12px

Border radius: radius-medium

Text: 16px Body, Regular, #000000

Hover: background #F6F6F6

Selected: background #F6F6F6, text #0EA5E9, checkmark icon (ti-check, 16px, #0EA5E9) anchored right

Disabled option: text #A3A3A3 at 45% opacity, not interactive

Transition: duration-instant (100ms), ease-out

iii. Action Menu Dropdown

A contextual menu that appears when the user triggers a more-options control, typically a ti-dots or ti-dots-vertical icon button. Contains a short list of actions relevant to a specific item or context. Never used for navigation.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-large (Canva 70)

Padding: 8px

Min width: 180px

Shadow: 0px 8px 32px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.08)

Position: aligned to the trigger element. Appears to the left of the trigger if space on the right is insufficient.

Entrance and exit: identical to select dropdown.

Individual action items inside:

Height: 44px minimum

Padding: 10px 12px

Border radius: radius-medium (Canva 50)

Icon: optional, Tabler outline 20px, left of label, inherits text color
Text: 16px Body, Regular, #000000
Hover: background #F6F6F6
Destructive action item: text #FF3B30, icon #FF3B30
Destructive action hover: background #FEE2E2
Divider between action groups: 1px solid #EEEEEE, 4px vertical margin

iv. Dismissal Behavior

All dropdown variants dismiss under the following conditions:

- The user selects an option or link inside the dropdown
- The user clicks or taps anywhere outside the dropdown
- The user presses the Escape key
- On navigation dropdowns - the cursor leaves both the parent trigger and the dropdown panel

Dropdowns never require an explicit close button. If a close button feels necessary the content belongs in a modal instead.

v. Key Notes

Dropdowns are temporary. They never contain content the user needs to reference while interacting with something else on the page. If the content needs to persist while the user acts, use a modal or a sidebar panel instead.

The navigation dropdown uses a dark background because it floats over page content that may be light or dark depending on scroll position. The dark surface with blur ensures consistent readability regardless of what is behind it.

The select dropdown maximum height of 240px is a hard limit. Lists longer than this become difficult to scan. If a select input has more than eight options consider whether a search input with filtered results is a better pattern.

Never animate dropdown content independently from the dropdown panel itself. The panel animates as a single unit, and internal items do not stagger or animate separately.

vi. Do's and Don'ts

DO dismiss all dropdowns immediately when the user clicks outside. A dropdown that persists after losing focus traps the user.

DON'T put more than eight options in a select dropdown without adding search filtering. Long unfiltered lists frustrate users.

DO use the destructive action item style for any action menu item that results in data loss or an irreversible action.

DON'T use a dropdown for navigation on mobile. Mobile navigation uses the full-screen mobile menu panel defined in 7d.

DO align the select dropdown to the full width of its originating input field. A dropdown narrower than its trigger looks broken.

DON'T use dropdowns to display informational content. Dropdowns are for selection and action only. Information belongs in tooltips or inline text.

DO keep action menu items to a maximum of six. More than six actions in a contextual menu indicates the interface needs restructuring.

DON'T add entrance or exit animations longer than duration-short (250ms) to any dropdown. Slow dropdowns feel broken.

f. Modals

Modals are temporary overlay panels that appear above the current interface surface to present focused content or actions that require the user's immediate attention before continuing. They interrupt the current flow intentionally, so use them only when the task or information cannot be handled inline or in a dropdown.

Modals are the heaviest interruption pattern in the interface. They should be used sparingly and only when absolutely necessary.

i. Overlay

Every modal is accompanied by a full-screen overlay that sits between the modal and the page content beneath it. The overlay communicates that the page behind is temporarily inactive.

Background: #000000 at 45% opacity

Transition: opacity 0 → 1, duration-short (250ms), ease-out

Clicking or tapping the overlay dismisses the modal unless the modal requires a mandatory decision.

ii. Standard Modal

Used for confirmations, forms, and focused informational content that requires user interaction before returning to the page.



Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 1px solid #C4C4C4

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 32px

Max width: 480px

Width: 90% of viewport on mobile

Shadow: 0px 24px 64px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.16)

Position: centered horizontally and vertically in the viewport

Entrance: opacity 0 → 1, translateY 16px → 0px, duration-medium (350ms), ease-out

Exit: opacity 1 → 0, translateY 0px → 8px, duration-short (250ms), ease-in

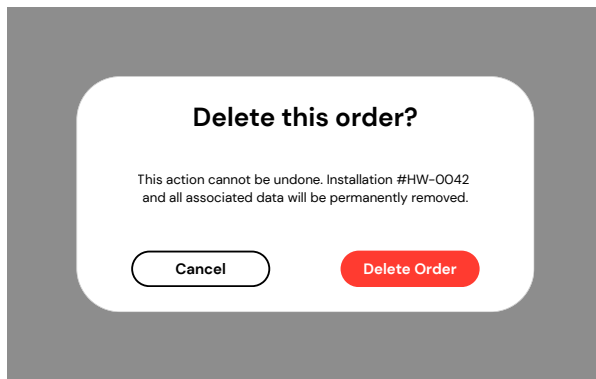
ii. Modal Anatomy

Every modal follows a consistent internal structure top to bottom:

1. Header: contains the modal title and close button, and is always present.
 - Title: H3, 24px Bold, #000000, left aligned
 - Close button: ti-x icon, 20px, #A3A3A3, anchored top right. On hover #000000. Touch target minimum 44x44px.
 - Gap below header: 16px divider line #EEEEEE, then 24px gap before body content
2. Body: the main content of the modal. Can contain text, form inputs, or informational content.
 - Text: 16px Body Regular, #525252
 - If the body content exceeds the modal height, the body scrolls internally. The header and footer remain fixed.
 - Maximum body scroll height: 60% of viewport height
3. Footer: contains the modal's action buttons, and is always present unless the modal is purely informational with a single close action.
 - Gap above footer: 24px
 - Button alignment: right aligned
 - Button order: secondary action left, primary action right
 - Gap between buttons: 12px

iii. Confirmation Modal

A specific modal variant used exclusively for confirming irreversible or high-impact actions. Triggered before any destructive button executes. The user must make an explicit choice, either confirm or cancel. There is no passive dismissal via overlay click.



Structure identical to standard modal with two differences:

The overlay is not dismissible by clicking. The user must interact with one of the two buttons.

The primary action button uses the destructive button spec from 7a - #FF3B30 background, #FFFFFF text.

Example structure:

Title: "Delete this order?"

Body: "This action cannot be undone. Installation #HW-0042 and all associated data will be permanently removed."

Footer: Cancel (secondary button) and Delete Order (destructive button)

iv. Informational Modal

Used to surface important information the user needs to read before continuing. Contains no form inputs. Contains one action only, an acknowledgment button that dismisses the modal.

Structure identical to standard modal. Footer contains a single primary button, which is centered, full width of the modal content area.

v. Key Notes

Modals never open on top of other modals. If a flow requires sequential modals, complete and dismiss the first before opening the second.

Never use a modal to display content the user needs to reference while doing something else. If the user needs to see the modal content while interacting with the page, use a sidebar panel or inline expansion instead.

Never open a modal as the result of another modal action unless it is a confirmation of a destructive action triggered from within the first modal. Even then, reconsider the flow.

The close button is always present in the top right corner of every modal except confirmation modals where a mandatory decision is required. On confirmation modals the close button is removed, since the user must choose an action.

Error messages inside modals follow the same inline error pattern defined in 7b. They appear directly below the field that caused them, not as a separate alert at the top of the modal.

Modal titles are always specific. "Are you sure?" is not an acceptable modal title. "Delete Installation #HW-0042?" is correct.

vi. Do's and Don'ts

DO use modals only when the task genuinely cannot be handled inline. Every modal is an interruption, therefore justify it.

DON'T stack modals. One modal at a time, always.

DO always include a close button on standard modals. Users need a clear exit path.

DON'T include a close button or dismissible overlay on confirmation modals. The user must make a deliberate choice.

DO keep modal body copy concise. If the content requires more than three short paragraphs the modal is the wrong pattern.

DON'T use a modal to display a success state after a form submission. Use a toast notification instead and return the user to the page.

DO right align buttons in the modal footer with the secondary action on the left and the primary action on the right. This is the consistent reading order for actions.

DON'T use a modal for navigation. If the user needs to go somewhere else the modal is the wrong pattern entirely.

DO make confirmation modal titles specific and action-oriented. The user should understand exactly what they are confirming from the title alone.

g. Toasts and Alerts

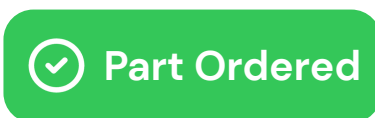
Toasts and alerts are notification components that communicate the result of a user action or a system event. They tell the user what just happened, what is currently happening, or what requires their attention. Both use the semantic color system exclusively. Their color is never decorative, it always carries meaning.

Toasts and alerts are distinct patterns with distinct purposes. They are never used interchangeably.

i. Toasts

Toasts are brief, non-blocking notifications that appear temporarily to confirm that an action completed. They do not require user interaction. They appear, communicate, and dismiss automatically. The user never needs to act on a toast, and if action is required, use an alert instead.

Position: bottom center of the viewport on mobile. Bottom right on desktop. Always above the bottom navigation bar on mobile.



Background: #3A3A3B

Text: #FFFFFF

Border radius: radius-large

Padding: 14px 20px

Shadow: 0px 8px 24px rgba(0,0,0,0.16)

Max width: 420px on desktop. 90% of viewport width on mobile.

Entrance: opacity 0 → 1, translateY 12px → 0px, duration-short (250ms), ease-out

Auto dismiss: after 4 seconds

Exit: opacity 1 → 0, translateY 0px → 12px, duration-short (250ms), ease-in

Toast anatomy, left to right:

1. Semantic icon – Tabler outline, 20px, semantic color. Always present.
2. Message text – 14px Body Regular, #FFFFFF. One line preferred. Two lines maximum.
3. Optional action link – 14px Body Bold, #0EA5E9. A single text link for an immediately relevant action. "Undo" or "View" only. Never a full button.
4. Optional close button – ti-x, 16px, #FFFFFF at 50% opacity. Present only when auto-dismiss is disabled.

Toast variants by semantic color:

Success toast – icon ti-circle-check, #34C759

Error toast – icon ti-circle-x, #FF3B30

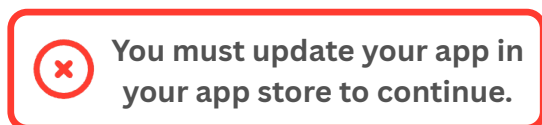
Warning toast – icon ti-alert-triangle, #FF9F0A

Info toast – icon ti-info-circle, #0EA5E9

If multiple toasts are triggered in sequence they stack vertically with 8px gap. Maximum three toasts visible simultaneously. A fourth toast dismisses the oldest.

ii. Alerts

Alerts are persistent, in-page notification banners that communicate an ongoing system state or a condition requiring the user's attention. Unlike toasts they do not auto-dismiss. They remain visible until the condition is resolved or the user explicitly dismisses them.



Alerts appear inline within the page layout, not floating above it. They sit at the top of the relevant content area or at the top of a form, directly above the content they relate to.

Background: #FFFFFF

Border left: 4px solid, semantic color

Border: 1px solid, semantic color at 30% opacity on remaining three sides

Border radius: radius-medium (Canva 50)

Padding: 16px 20px

Width: 100% of its container

Alert anatomy — left to right:

1. Semantic icon — Tabler outline, 20px, semantic color. Always present.
2. Content — stacked vertically
 - Title: 14px Body Bold, #000000. Optional but recommended.
 - Body: 14px Body Regular, #525252. The explanatory message.
3. Close button — ti-x, 16px, #A3A3A3, anchored right. On hover #000000. Present on all dismissible alerts.

Alert variants by semantic color:

Success alert — icon ti-circle-check, #34C759 border left

Error alert — icon ti-circle-x, #FF3B30 border left

Warning alert — icon ti-alert-triangle, #FF9F0A border left

Info alert — icon ti-info-circle, #0EA5E9 border left

iii. Choosing Between Toast and Alert

Use a toast when:

- An action completed successfully and the user needs brief confirmation
- The notification is purely informational and requires no action
- The condition is temporary and resolves on its own

Use an alert when:

- The condition is ongoing and the user may need to act on it
- The notification relates specifically to a section or form on the page
- The message requires more than one line to communicate clearly
- The user needs to read and understand the message before continuing

iv. Key Notes

Never use a toast for an error that requires user action to resolve. If the user needs to do something about the error, use an alert placed inline near the relevant content.

Never use an alert for a success confirmation after a simple action. A form successfully submitted does not need a persistent banner, it needs a toast.

Toast messages are written in past tense, since the action already happened. "Changes saved." not "Your changes have been saved successfully."

Alert messages are written in present tense, since the condition currently exists. "Your subscription expires in 3 days." not "Your subscription expired."

Never include more than one action link in a toast. If the situation requires multiple actions it belongs in a modal or an alert.

Toasts never contain form inputs, expandable content, or complex interactions. If the notification requires any of these it is not a toast.

v. Do's and Don'ts

DO use semantic colors consistently. A green toast always means success. A red toast always means something failed. Never deviate from this.

DON'T use a toast for errors that require user action. Toasts auto-dismiss. The user may not see it before it disappears.

DO write toast messages in past tense and keep them to one line wherever possible.

DON'T stack more than three toasts simultaneously. Dismiss the oldest when a fourth is triggered.

DO place alerts inline above the content they relate to. A form validation alert belongs above the form, not at the top of the page.

DON'T use an alert for a routine success confirmation. That is a toast's job.

DO always include a close button on dismissible alerts. Users need control over their interface.

DON'T auto-dismiss alerts. They communicate ongoing conditions, they stay until the condition resolves or the user dismisses them.

h. Progress Indicators

Progress indicators communicate the status of an ongoing process to the user. They answer one question, that is how far along is this? Used across all Howard interfaces where the user is moving through a multi-step installation process and needs constant orientation about where they are and what remains.

A progress indicator is never decorative. Every instance communicates real system or process state.

i. Progress Bar

A horizontal bar that fills from left to right to represent advancement through a process. Used for setup flows, file uploads, installation progress, and any process with a measurable completion percentage.

Track background: #EEEEEE

Fill: #EBC736

Height: 4px

Border radius: radius-pill (Canva 100)

Width: 100% of its container

Fill transition: duration-medium (350ms), linear easing. The fill never jumps instantly, it always advances smoothly.

A step label sits directly above the progress bar, left aligned.

Format: "Step 2 of 4"

Text: 13px Caption Regular, #A3A3A3

Gap between label and bar: 8px

Percentage variant is used for file uploads and installation progress:

A percentage value sits directly to the right of the bar, right aligned.

Format: "64%"

Text: 13px Caption Regular, #A3A3A3

Never show both a step label and a percentage on the same progress bar. Choose one format per context.

ii. Step Indicator

A discrete visual representation of a multi-step flow showing individual steps as connected nodes.

Step node (completed):

Shape: circle, 24px diameter

Background: #EBC736

Icon: ti-check, 14px, #000000

Step node (current):

Shape: circle, 24px diameter

Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 2px solid #EBC736

Inner dot: 8px circle, #EBC736, centered

Step node (upcoming):

Shape: circle, 24px diameter

Background: #FFFFFF

Border: 2px solid #EEEEEE

Connector line between nodes:

Height: 2px

Background: #EEEEEE for upcoming connections

Background: #EBC736 for completed connections

Width: fills the space between nodes

Step labels sit directly below each node:

Text: 11px Label Bold, uppercase

Completed and current: #000000

Upcoming: #A3A3A3

Gap between node and label: 6px

iii. Spinner

A circular loading indicator used when a process is ongoing but its completion percentage is unknown. Used during API calls, content loading, and Arken's background configuration processes.

Two sizes:

Small — 16px diameter. Used inline with text or inside buttons.

Default — 32px diameter. Used as a standalone loading state for content areas.

Color: #0EA5E9 on light backgrounds. #FFFFFF on dark backgrounds.

Animation: continuous rotation, 360 degrees, 800ms per rotation, linear easing.

The spinner always appears with a text label beneath or beside it unless it is inline within a button. A spinner with no label leaves the user with no context for what is happening.

Spinner label text: 13px Caption Regular, #A3A3A3. Examples:

"Setting up your Howard..."

"Connecting to your network..."

"Verifying installation..."

"Just a moment..."

Never use the brand yellow #EBC736 for the spinner. The spinner uses the primary action blue #0EA5E9 because it represents an ongoing system process, not a brand moment.

iv. Skeleton Loader

Used when a content area is loading and its structure is known in advance. Displays a placeholder that mirrors the shape and layout of the content that will appear, reducing perceived load time.

Background: #EEEEEE

Animation: shimmer – a subtle lighter highlight sweeps left to right continuously across the skeleton element.

Shimmer color: #FFFFFF at 60% opacity

Shimmer duration: 1.5 seconds per sweep, linear, looping

Border radius: matches the border radius of the content it is replacing

Skeleton elements never use brand colors. They are always neutral grey placeholders.

Use skeleton loaders for:

- Card content loading on initial page render
- List items loading from an API
- Profile or account information loading in Arken

Do not use skeleton loaders for:

- Processes that complete in under 300ms, show the content directly
- Indeterminate processes where the structure is unknown, use a spinner instead

v. Key Notes

The progress bar fill uses #EBC736 brand yellow because it represents Howard's ownership of the setup process. This is one of the permitted uses of yellow as defined in the color system. It is not text and not a background. It is a brand accent on a structural element.

The step indicator gives the user a map of the whole journey. The progress bar communicates advancement within the current step. They serve complementary purposes and are never redundant.

Never show a spinner and a progress bar for the same process simultaneously. Choose the pattern that matches what is known. If completion percentage is measurable use a progress bar, if it is not use a spinner.

Spinner labels update in real time to reflect what is actually happening. A label that reads "Setting up your Howard..." for thirty seconds while the system does multiple different things is less reassuring than labels that update as each sub-process completes.

vi. Do's and Don'ts

DO always label a standalone spinner. A spinning circle with no context creates anxiety.

DON'T use a spinner for a process where completion percentage is known and measurable. Use a progress bar instead.

DO update spinner labels in real time during Arken's setup process. Specific labels are more reassuring than generic ones.

DON'T use #EBC736 for the spinner color. The spinner uses #0EA5E9, and it represents a system process, not a brand moment.

DO use skeleton loaders for content areas where the layout is predictable. They significantly reduce perceived load time.

DON'T show skeleton loaders for processes that complete in under 300ms. Flashing a skeleton for a fraction of a second is more disruptive than showing nothing.

DO use the step indicator and progress bar together in Arken's setup flow. They serve different purposes and work better as a pair.

DON'T allow the progress bar fill to jump instantly between values. Always transition smoothly over duration—medium (350ms).

I. Empty States

Empty states are the screens or content areas a user encounters when there is no content to display yet. They occur on first use before any data exists, after a user has cleared all content, or when a search or filter returns no results. An empty state is not a failure, rather it is an opportunity to orient the user and give them a clear path forward.

A blank screen with no explanation is never acceptable. Every empty state communicates three things: what this area is for, why it is currently empty, and what the user can do next.

i. Anatomy

Every empty state contains the following elements stacked vertically and centered horizontally within its container:

1. Illustration or icon – visual anchor that communicates the context of the empty area at a glance.
2. Title – the primary message. Short and specific.
3. Body – a single sentence explaining why it is empty and what it is for.
4. Action – a button or link giving the user a clear next step. Optional only when no action is available or appropriate.

All four elements are center aligned. The empty state never left aligns its content.

ii. Icon Treatment

Empty states use a single Tabler outline icon at 48px as the visual anchor. The icon is always contextually relevant, and it represents the type of content that belongs in the empty area.

Icon color: #C4C4C4 Container: none. The icon sits directly above the title with no background or border. Gap between icon and title: 16px

Examples: Empty inbox → ti-mail No tasks → ti-clipboard No installations → ti-device-desktop No search results → ti-search No team members → ti-users

Never use the brand yellow #EBC736 on an empty state icon. Empty states are neutral. Yellow implies a brand moment or an active state, neither of which applies here.

iii. Title

The title is the primary message of the empty state. It is specific to the context and written in a warm, direct tone consistent with Howard's brand voice.

Text: H3, 24px Bold, #000000 Max width: 320px Gap below title: 8px

Title conventions:

- State what is missing, not what went wrong. "No tasks yet." not "You haven't added any tasks."
- Never use the word "empty" in the title. "No tasks yet." not "This area is empty."
- Never use generic titles. "Nothing here yet." is not acceptable. "No installations yet." is correct.

iv. Body

One sentence that explains the context and points toward the action. Written in Howard's voice, which is warm, direct, and never condescending.

Text: 16px Body Regular, #525252 Max width: 360px Gap below body: 24px

Body conventions:

- One sentence only. Two sentences maximum in exceptional cases.
- Always end with an implied or explicit next step. "Add your first task to get started." or "Text Howard to get started."
- Never explain the obvious. If the title already communicates the situation fully the body adds context, not repetition.

v. Action

The action gives the user a direct path out of the empty state. It is the most important element for conversion. A user who sees an empty state and has no action to take is a user who may leave.

Uses the primary button spec from 7a – #0EA5E9 background, #FFFFFF text, pill border radius.

Max width: fits content. Never stretches full width in an empty state.

Action label conventions:

- Specific and action-oriented. "Add your first task." not "Get started."
- Never "Click here" or "Learn more" as standalone labels.
- If no action is available — for example a search that returned no results – omit the button entirely and adjust the body copy to suggest a different search term or filter.

vi. Empty State Variants

First Use The user has just set up Howard and is viewing a content area for the first time. Tone is welcoming and encouraging.

Icon: contextually relevant Title: "No tasks yet." Body: "Text Howard to get started – it will handle the rest." Action: Primary button – "Learn how Howard works"

Cleared State The user has intentionally removed all content from an area. Tone is neutral and confirming.

Icon: contextually relevant Title: "All clear." Body: "Everything in this area has been removed." Action: None unless content can be restored.

No Search Results A search or filter returned zero results. Tone is helpful and redirecting.

Icon: ti-search Title: "No results for '[search term]'." Body: "Try a different search term or clear your filters." Action: Text link – "Clear filters" – not a full button.

Error State Content failed to load due to a system error. Tone is honest and actionable.

Icon: ti-wifi-off or ti-alert-circle Title: "Something went wrong." Body: "We couldn't load this content. Check your connection and try again." Action: Primary button – "Try again"

Sizing and Placement

Empty states within a full page occupy the vertical center of the available content area. They are never pinned to the top.

Empty states within a card or panel are centered within the card's content area.

Minimum container height for a full page empty state: 400px. Below this height the empty state compresses but never clips or hides any of its elements.

Minimum container height for a card or panel empty state: 200px. At this height the action button is removed if space is insufficient, but title and body always remain.

vii. Key Notes

Empty states in Arken's operational interface are particularly important. A user who has just completed setup and opens Howard's interface for the first time should feel welcomed and oriented, not confronted with a blank screen. The first use empty state for Arken is one of the most important moments in the entire product experience.

Never style an empty state to look like an error. An area with no content yet is not a problem — styling it in red or with an alert icon implies something went wrong when nothing did.

The no search results variant never uses an error color. It uses the neutral grey icon and standard text colors. A failed search is not a system failure.

viii. Do's and Don'ts

DO always include a title and body in every empty state. A blank area with only an icon is incomplete.

DON'T use the word "empty" in any empty state title or body copy. It is redundant and slightly clinical.

DO write empty state copy in Howard's brand voice, which warm, direct, occasionally reassuring. Never robotic or generic.

DON'T style empty states with error colors unless the content genuinely failed to load due to a system error.

DO always provide an action when one exists. A user with no path forward will disengage.

DON'T stretch the action button to full width in an empty state. It should fit its content and sit centered below the body text.

DO use contextually specific icons. The icon should immediately communicate what type of content belongs in this area.

DON'T use #EBC736 on any empty state element. Empty states are neutral moments, and yellow implies active brand presence which is tonally wrong here.

DO treat the first use empty state in Arken as a product moment. It is the first thing a user sees after completing setup. It should feel welcoming and clear.

8. Voice and Microcopy

This section defines how Howard AI interfaces sound. Every word in every interface is a brand moment, like button labels, error messages, loading states, confirmation dialogs, and empty states all communicate who Howard is as much as the visual design does. Microcopy that is generic, robotic, or unclear undermines the entire product experience regardless of how polished the interface looks.

a. Principles

Howard's interface voice follows the same brand voice defined in the Howard AI Brand Guidelines. Confident, warm, direct, confident, and occasionally witty. Applied to microcopy this means:

Clear over clever. The interface is not a place for wordplay that sacrifices comprehension. Every label, message, and instruction must be immediately understood by any user regardless of technical ability.

Direct over polite. Howard does not say "We're sorry, but it seems there may have been an issue." Howard says "Something went wrong. Try again." Brevity and directness are a form of respect for the user's time.

Human over robotic. Error codes, technical jargon, and system language never appear in user-facing copy. Translate every system event into plain language a non-technical user understands immediately.

Specific over generic. Generic microcopy is invisible and forgettable. Specific microcopy communicates and builds trust. "Delete Installation #HW-0042?" is specific. "Are you sure?" is generic.

b. Button Labels

Button labels are always verbs. They describe exactly what will happen when the button is pressed. The user should never have to guess what a button does.

DO:

- "Save Changes"
- "Delete Order"
- "Get Started"
- "Send Message"
- "Try Again"
- "Add Team Member"

DON'T:

- "OK" - what does OK confirm? Be specific.
- "Submit" - submit what? Name the thing being submitted.
- "Yes" / "No" - pair these with a specific action label instead.
- "Click Here" - never acceptable in any context.
- "Learn More" as a standalone button label. Pair it with the subject. "Learn how Howard works."

Destructive button labels name the destructive action explicitly.

- "Delete Order" not "Confirm"
- "Remove Team Member" not "Yes, remove"
- "Cancel Subscription" not "Proceed"

c. Error Messages

Error messages tell the user what went wrong and how to fix it. They are never technical, never vague, and never blame the user.

Three parts to every error message:

1. What happened. One short sentence in plain language.
2. Why it happened. Optional, only if it adds actionable context.
3. What to do next. Always present unless the resolution is self-evident.

DO:

- "That email address is already in use. Try signing in instead."
- "Your session expired. Sign in again to continue."
- "We couldn't connect to your network. Check your connection and try again."
- "This field is required."

DON'T:

- "Error 422: Unprocessable Entity"
- "An unexpected error occurred."
- "Invalid input."
- "Something went wrong." as a standalone message with no next step. Always pair it with an action.

Error messages are written in second person - "your connection" not "the connection." This makes the message feel directed at the specific user situation rather than generic.

Error messages never start with "Sorry" or "We apologize." Howard does not apologize for system states. It informs and directs.

d. Placeholder Text

Placeholder text appears inside empty input fields as a formatting hint. It disappears when the user begins typing. It is never a substitute for a visible label.

Placeholder text shows the expected format, not a description of the field.

DO:

- "your@email.com"
- "+1 (555) 000-0000"
- "Search installations..."
- "DD/MM/YYYY"

DON'T:

- "Enter your email address here"
- "Please type your phone number"
- "Type to search"
- Repeating the field label as placeholder text

Placeholder text is always written in lowercase unless it contains a proper noun or format that requires capitalization.

e. Loading and Processing Messages

Loading messages appear alongside spinners and progress bars during processing states. They communicate what is currently happening in plain, specific language.

Loading messages update in real time during multi-step processes like Arken's setup flow. A message that reads the same for thirty seconds while multiple things happen is less reassuring than messages that reflect actual system activity.

DO:

- "Setting up your Howard..."
- "Connecting to your network..."
- "Verifying installation..."
- "Checking for updates..."
- "Almost done..."

DON'T:

- "Loading..."
- "Please wait..."
- "Processing..."
- "This may take a moment..."

Loading messages end with an ellipsis to communicate an ongoing state. They never end with a period, because a period implies completion.

f. Confirmation Messages

Confirmation messages appear in modal titles and toast notifications after a successful action. They confirm specifically what happened.

Toast confirmation conventions:

- Past tense. The action already completed.
- One sentence maximum.
- Name the thing that was acted on where possible.

DO:

- "Changes saved."
- "Installation #HW-0042 deleted."
- "Team member added."
- "Message sent."

DON'T:

- "Success!"
- "Done!"
- "Your request has been processed successfully."
- "Operation completed."

Modal confirmation title conventions:

- Present tense question. The action has not yet happened.
- Name the specific thing being confirmed.
- End with a question mark.

DO:

- "Delete Installation #HW-0042?"
- "Remove Sarah from your team?"
- "Cancel your subscription?"

DON'T:

- "Are you sure?"
- "Confirm action"
- "Please confirm"

g. Empty State Copy

Empty state copy follows the rules defined in 7i. Key voice conventions summarized here:

Titles are written in second person present tense. "No tasks yet." not "You have not created any tasks."

Body copy is warm and action-oriented. It ends with a clear implied or explicit next step. Never use the word "empty." Never use the word "nothing." Both are clinical and slightly negative for what is a neutral state.

DO:

- "No tasks yet. Text Howard to get started."
- "All clear. Everything here has been removed."
- "No results for 'Barbados flights'. Try a different search."

DON'T:

- "This list is empty."
- "Nothing to show here."
- "No data available."

h. Onboarding and Setup Copy

Arken's setup flow is the most important microcopy surface in the entire product. It is the first extended interaction a new user has with Howard. Every instruction, label, and confirmation in the setup flow must be exceptionally clear, reassuring, and warm.

Setup flow copy conventions:

Step titles are action-oriented and specific.

- "Connect to your network" not "Network Setup"
- "Set your preferences" not "Configuration"
- "Meet Howard" not "Complete"

Instruction copy is written at a reading level accessible to any user regardless of technical ability. If a step requires technical input explain exactly what is needed and why in plain language.

Progress confirmations at the end of each step are warm and specific.

- "Network connected. Howard is online."
- "Preferences saved. Howard knows what you need."
- "You're all set. Howard is ready."

The final setup completion message is the most important single piece of copy in the entire product. It should feel like a genuine moment. The user has just set up something meaningful. It is not "Setup complete." It is something Howard would actually say.

Example: "Howard is ready to lend a helping hand."

i. Do's and Don'ts

DO write every button label as a verb describing the exact action.

DON'T use "OK", "Submit", "Yes", or "No" as standalone button labels.

DO write error messages in plain language with a clear next step.

DON'T use technical error codes or system language in any user-facing message.

DO update loading messages in real time during multi-step processes.

DON'T use "Loading..." or "Please wait..." as loading messages. They communicate nothing specific.

DO write toast confirmations in past tense. The action already happened.

DON'T write modal confirmation titles as "Are you sure?" Always name the specific action.

DO keep all microcopy consistent with Howard's brand voice, which is confident, warm, direct.

DON'T let microcopy sound robotic, generic, or corporate. If it could appear on any product from any company it is not Howard's voice.

9. Accessibility

This section defines the accessibility standards applied across all HowardAI interfaces. Accessibility is not an optional layer added after design is complete, rather it is a foundational requirement built into every component, color decision, and interaction pattern from the start. An interface that excludes users based on ability is an incomplete interface.

Howard AI targets WCAG 2.1 AA compliance as the minimum standard across all surfaces.

a. Color and Contrast

Color is never the sole means of communicating information. Every use of color to convey meaning, like semantic states, active navigation, and selected options, is always paired with a secondary indicator such as an icon, a label, or a shape change.

i. Minimum contrast ratios – WCAG 2.1 AA:

Normal text (below 18px): 4.5:1 minimum against its background
Large text (18px and above, or 14px Bold and above): 3:1 minimum against its background
UI components and graphical elements: 3:1 minimum against adjacent colors

ii. Confirmed passing pairs from the Howard color system:

#000000 on #FFFFFF — 21:1. Passes all levels.

#000000 on #F6F6F6 — 19.6:1. Passes all levels.

#525252 on #FFFFFF — 7.4:1. Passes AA for normal text.

#525252 on #F6F6F6 — 6.9:1. Passes AA for normal text.

#A3A3A3 on #FFFFFF — 2.9:1. Passes AA for large text only. Never use for normal body text.

#FFFFFF on #3A3A3B — 10.4:1. Passes all levels.

#FFFFFF on #0EA5E9 — 2.9:1. Passes AA for large text and UI components.

Acceptable for buttons at 16px Bold.

#FFFFFF on #FF3B30 — 3.2:1. Passes AA for large text and UI components.

Acceptable for destructive buttons at 16px Bold.

#FFFFFF on #34C759 — 1.9:1. Fails AA. Never use white text on the success green.

#000000 on #34C759 — 4.5:1. Passes AA for normal text. Use dark text on success green always.

#000000 on #EBC736 — 7.2:1. Passes all levels. However yellow backgrounds are prohibited by the color system regardless of contrast.

iii. Critical rules:

Never use #A3A3A3 for body text on any background. It is permitted for placeholder text and disabled text only, and contexts where reduced visibility is intentional and expected.

Never use white text on #34C759 success green. Always use #000000 on green surfaces.

The 45% opacity disabled state must always be checked against its specific background before implementation. Opacity-based disabled states can fail contrast minimums depending on the underlying surface color.

b. Typography and Readability

Minimum font size on any interface surface is 13px. Nothing renders smaller than this. 11px Label text is permitted only for uppercase tracked labels where the bold weight and letter spacing compensate for the reduced size, never for sentence-case body copy.

Line length for all paragraph text is constrained to a maximum of 680px or 75 characters per line. Lines longer than this reduce reading speed and comprehension.

Text is never justified. Left aligned only for all body copy, labels, and interface text. Justified text creates uneven word spacing that reduces readability particularly for users with dyslexia.

Text never overlays images or complex backgrounds directly. If text must appear over an image a sufficient background overlay or blur must be applied to ensure contrast compliance.

Never use italic text for body copy. Italics reduce readability at small sizes and are particularly difficult for users with dyslexia. Italic is reserved for specific brand emphasis moments only, never for extended reading.

c. Focus States

Every interactive element must have a visible focus state for keyboard navigation. Users who navigate interfaces using a keyboard, which includes many users with motor disabilities, rely heavily on focus indicators to know where they are.

Howard's focus ring specification: Style: 2px solid #EBC736 Offset: 2px from the element edge Applied to: every button, link, input field, select, checkbox, radio button, toggle, and interactive icon

On yellow elements where the yellow focus ring would be invisible: Style: 2px solid #000000 Offset: 2px from the element edge

Focus states are never removed with outline: none in CSS without providing an equivalent custom focus indicator. Removing focus states without replacement is a direct accessibility violation.

Focus order follows the logical reading order of the page, left to right, top to bottom. Interactive elements that appear visually out of order in the DOM create a confusing keyboard navigation experience.

d. Touch Targets

Every tappable or clickable element on any surface maintains a minimum touch target size of 44x44px. This applies regardless of the visual size of the element.

A small icon button that renders at 20x20px visually still has a 44x44px invisible interactive area surrounding it. This is implemented in code with padding or a minimum height and width applied to the interactive element.

This rule applies on all surfaces, not mobile only. Desktop click targets below 44x44px are also a violation.

Spacing between adjacent touch targets is a minimum of 8px. Touch targets that are too close together cause accidental activations particularly for users with motor impairments.

e. Screen Reader Support

All images, icons, and non-text visual elements include descriptive alternative text or are marked as decorative.

Decorative icons, such as icons that accompany a text label and add no additional meaning, are marked with `aria-hidden="true"`. The text label provides the accessible name.

Functional icons, such as icons that are the sole interactive element with no visible text label, must have an `aria-label` attribute describing their action. "Close modal" not "X". "Open menu" not "hamburger".

Images that convey meaning include descriptive alt text. Alt text describes what the image communicates, not what it literally depicts. A photo of Howard hardware installed in a living room has alt text "Howard Home unit installed in a residential living room" not "black computer tower".

Decorative images that add no informational value use empty alt text – `alt=""`. This tells screen readers to skip the element entirely.

Form inputs are always associated with their labels using the HTML `for` and `id` attributes or `aria-labelledby`. A visually positioned label that is not programmatically associated with its input is invisible to screen readers.

Error messages are associated with their input fields using `aria-describedby`. This ensures screen readers announce the error message when the user focuses the field.

f. Motion and Reduced Motion

All animations respect the user's system-level reduced motion preference as defined in Section 5.7.

When reduced motion is enabled:

- All transitions default to instant opacity changes
- No translate, scale, or rotate animations
- Progress bars advance instantly without fill animation
- Skeleton loader shimmer animation is removed
- the skeleton displays as a static grey element
- Spinner continues to display but rotation animation is removed
- replace with a static indicator or pulsing opacity instead

Implementing reduced motion in code: All animations are wrapped in a prefers-reduced-motion media query. The default styles contain full animations. The reduced motion query overrides them with instant transitions.

g. Forms and Inputs

All form inputs follow the accessibility requirements established in 7b. Additional requirements:

Required fields are always marked visually and programmatically. Visual marking uses a text indicator – the word "Required" in 11px Label text below the field label, #FF3B30. Never use an asterisk alone as the required indicator, since asterisks are not universally understood.

Error messages are announced to screen readers immediately on validation. This requires `aria-live="polite"` on the error message container so screen readers announce the message without requiring the user to navigate to it.

Autocomplete attributes are applied to all relevant input fields. Name fields use `autocomplete="name"`. Email fields use `autocomplete="email"`. Phone fields use `autocomplete="tel"`. This assists users who rely on autofill and reduces input burden for all users.

Input fields never rely on color alone to communicate their state. The error state uses both a red border and error text below the field. The focused state uses both a yellow border and a focus ring. Both changes are always present simultaneously.

h. Do's and Don'ts

DO check every text and background color combination against WCAG 2.1 AA contrast requirements before implementation.

DON'T use color as the sole means of communicating state or meaning. Always pair color with a secondary indicator.

DO maintain visible focus states on every interactive element. Never use outline: none without a custom replacement.

DON'T use #A3A3A3 for body text. It is for placeholder and disabled text only.

DO apply a minimum 44x44px touch target to every interactive element on every surface.

DON'T remove the touch target size requirement on desktop. Small click targets are an accessibility issue on all devices.

DO associate every form label with its input programmatically. A visually positioned label is not enough.

DON'T use italic text for body copy or extended reading. Reserve italics for specific brand emphasis moments only.

DO respect the reduced motion system preference. Wrap all animations in a prefers-reduced-motion media query.

DON'T use white text on #34C759 success green. The contrast ratio fails WCAG AA. Always use #000000 on green surfaces.

DO write descriptive alt text for meaningful images. Describe what the image communicates, not what it literally shows.

DON'T mark functional icon buttons as aria-hidden. They need an aria-label describing their action.

DO mark required fields with the word "Required" in text. Never rely on an asterisk alone.

DON'T use aria-live regions excessively. Overuse causes screen readers to announce too frequently and creates a disorienting experience.



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